

Mazu and the Hongzhou School

1. Historical setting

Mazu Daoyi and his disciples became central to the later memory of Tang-dynasty Chan. Mario Poceski's reconstruction is important because it works from the earliest available strata rather than assuming that later Song encounter dialogues transparently report eighth-century conversations. Hongzhou's importance is institutional as well as doctrinal: it helped make Chan an empire-wide monastic movement.

2. 'Mind is Buddha'

The formula can be heard as metaphysics, pedagogy, or both. At minimum it rejects seeking Buddha as an external object. Yet a teacher who tells a student 'mind is Buddha' may not be asserting that every ordinary preference is enlightened. The phrase reorients the locus of practice. Its meaning depends on the account of delusion, attachment, and responsive activity supplied around it.

3. 'Neither mind nor Buddha'

Later stories often pair affirmative formulas with reversals: first 'mind is Buddha,' later 'neither mind nor Buddha.' The reversal prevents a useful instruction from hardening into an essence. This is a recurring Zen device: doctrine becomes medicine indexed to a pathology. A medicine metaphor, however, does not make interpretation arbitrary. One must identify the pathology each statement is supposed to treat.

4. Ordinary mind

'Ordinary mind is the Way' is easily romanticized into 'whatever I already do is Zen.' That reading erases the monastic context in which ordinary conduct was structured by schedules, precepts, teacher-student roles, ritual, and training. 'Ordinary' can oppose contrived searching without endorsing every unexamined habit. The phrase destabilizes a sacred/profane split while leaving room for demanding cultivation.

5. Antinomianism objection

Objection: if every act manifests Buddha-nature, there is no basis for preferring disciplined conduct to anger, greed, or harm. Response available to Hongzhou interpreters: nondual ontology does not erase causal or ethical distinctions; the issue is whether actions arise through grasping and reification. The response must still explain why rhetoric celebrating spontaneity does not license self-serving claims of enlightenment.

6. Practice without fabrication

A recurring tension is that practice cannot manufacture awakening as a new object, yet training plainly occurs. One resolution distinguishes instrumental production from enactment: practice does not create Buddha-nature, but it can enact, disclose, stabilize, or stop obscuring a capacity not produced by the practice. Later Soto accounts of practice-realization will sharpen this distinction.

7. Historical caution

Do not reconstruct Mazu solely from famous anecdotes compiled much later. Use them, but mark their date and genre. A Song compiler selecting Tang masters is simultaneously representing Tang Chan and constructing Song Chan's ancestry. The source has two temporal locations at once: the world it depicts and the world that needed that depiction.

1. What kind of claim is 'ordinary mind is the Way'?

Two questions are easily confused. Metaphysical: is ordinary mind already Buddha in some ultimate sense? Practical: what should a practitioner cease adding or seeking in order for ordinary activity to function without distortion? Poceski's reconstruction of Hongzhou materials is useful because it resists reducing Mazu to a one-line slogan. The same corpus can affirm 'mind is Buddha,' deny fixation on that formula, and warn against deliberate fabrication.

2. Two subjectivist readings

- 1 Whatever I happen to feel is Zen, because my present mind is Buddha.
- 2 No training can improve ordinary mind, because any improvement would make it non-ordinary.

Both readings are unstable. The first cannot explain the tradition's extensive criticism of greed, delusion, attachment, and imitation. The second cannot explain teaching communities, precepts, discipline, and repeated warnings against contrivance. 'Ordinary' is therefore not equivalent to unexamined habit.

3. An argument from disagreement

- 1 Hongzhou sources praise ordinary mind and criticize seeking a Buddha outside present activity.
- 2 The same sources distinguish free functioning from attachment, conceptual fabrication, and compulsive discrimination.
- 3 Therefore the norm cannot be 'whatever presently occurs is equally awakened.'
- 4 A better account treats ordinariness as activity without the added project of manufacturing a sacred state, while allowing that entrenched grasping can obscure that mode of activity.

4. The queerness problem

A modern reader may hear 'mind is Buddha' as a strange metaphysical identity claim. Three kinds of strangeness should be separated. Metaphysical: does 'mind' name a substance or universal nature? Epistemological: how could one know the identity without merely repeating scripture? Practical: if the identity is already true, what can practice add? Hongzhou rhetoric often shifts pressure from the first question to the third. The point is less to postulate a hidden mental substance than to block the search for awakening as an object standing outside current functioning.

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